



ADOPTION OF LINUX AND OPEN SOURCE SOFTWARE

The Challenges and Opportunities

The hurdles faced in the adoption of open source by enterprises and the Indian government can easily be overcome if a planned, six-step approach is followed.

Open source has opened minds and provided a great amount of freedom of choice not just to organisations but to our government as well. In my view, open source has brought about a change in the way we view and adapt to technology. We are seeing a paradigm shift from packaged software to open source standards not just within organisations, but also at the government level. A significant amount of government administration processes have been simplified by employing various open source tools. In the last five years, there has been a sudden rise in open source developers being hired. There is a huge untapped potential for developers in the open source domain. However, it remains to be seen what measures the government is taking at the central and the state levels to implement this technology and how it is addressing the challenges associated with migrating to open source.

Both at the central and state levels, governments have formulated policies promoting the adoption of Linux and other open source software for several years now. Initiatives such as the National Resource Centre for Free and Open Source Software (NRCFOSS) and BOSS Linux from Centre for the Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) point to the government's level of involvement in spreading awareness about and driving the adoption of Free and

Open Source Software (FOSS). Individual bodies such as C-DAC and the National Informatics Center (NIC) have made enormous contributions to the adoption and migration of operations on the open source platform.

The government's emphasis on open standards such as the Open Document Format (ODF) has also helped create a favourable climate for the adoption of FOSS within the government. Setting up independent bodies to execute OSS adoption/migration projects is evidence of the high interest levels in this sector. For example, the State government of Assam insists that all office documents be shared only in the Open Document Format to maintain compatibility and this is a statutory message that appears in all mails. Similarly, the IT policy of the Government of Kerala is also very supportive of open source. In recent years, the hardware and software procurement policies of our government have been made largely vendor-neutral, creating a level playing field for Linux and open source software. Several massive projects such as the state service gateways, the National Knowledge Network, etc., are in the development phases now and for most of them the entire infrastructure is new, so Linux and open source software have been adopted.

The policy on Open Standards for e-governance notified by the Government of India in November, 2010 mandates adoption of royalty free open standards